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RAMNATH GOENKA

◆ IN 1932 ◆

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

Energy crisis is moving from oilfields to refineries

THE ENERGY crisis from the conflicts in West Asia and Russia-Ukraine is taking unprecedented forms. The present crunch isn't just about crude oil. Brent prices, at about \$102 per barrel, are nearly 55 per cent higher than a year ago, but below the March 2022 and July 2008 peaks of \$139.1 and \$147.5, respectively. The long-range drone and missile strikes by Ukraine and Iran have targeted refineries, driving up the prices of their products and byproducts more than that of crude. Diesel prices in the US are at a record \$6.5-plus a gallon, up 76.2 per cent year-on-year. Equally significant is sulphur. In normal times, India was importing this byproduct of refineries and natural gas processing plants — they remove it for making clean, low-emissions fuels — at \$200 or less per tonne. Today, that price is at \$1,000 and above.

Much of the sulphur recovered from oil and gas production gets converted into sulphuric acid, which is a core chemical for manufacturing phosphatic fertilisers. While the primary raw material for phosphorus (P) is rock phosphate, this ore cannot be used as fertiliser unless broken down into a water-soluble form for plants to absorb. For that, it has to be reacted with sulphuric acid, which then leads to the production of single super phosphate, di-ammonium phosphate and other P-containing complex fertilisers. India has managed to import adequate quantities of both urea and liquefied natural gas to enable the domestic production of this vital nitrogen-containing fertiliser. The same cannot be said, however, be said about phosphatic and complex fertilisers. Their imports as well as domestic manufacturing have been severely constrained by the global shortage of sulphur that is, in turn, courtesy of the sustained attacks on energy infrastructure in Russia and the Persian Gulf countries.

The millions of barrels of oil refining capacity in West Asia and Russia getting knocked out makes this energy crisis different from earlier ones. The shortages now are more in diesel, jet fuel and sulphur than in crude petroleum. This is also reflected in crack spreads — the price difference between crude oil and refined products — surging to all-time highs. That, by itself, may not be bad for India. Its 284.9 million tonnes (mt) output of refined petroleum products in 2025-26 was ahead of its domestic consumption of 243.2 mt and also the installed capacity of 258.1 mt. Thus, the country has no dearth of refining capacity, which also explains why no dry-outs of petrol or diesel are being reported in fuel outlets. But if sulphur is any indication, one cannot rule out those possibilities going ahead.

Greenland standoff ends. But with costs to NATO

ON THE face of it, the deal between the US, Denmark and Greenland, announced last Friday, does not appear to confer on Washington powers substantially greater than those it already enjoys under the Greenland Defence Agreement. Signed in 1951 against the backdrop of the emerging Soviet threat, that pact gave the US broad rights to construct and operate military facilities in Greenland, as well as access to its airspace and waters for military purposes. The new deal may expand the US military presence and give Washington a veto over third-party military activity and certain sensitive investments, but much of what President Donald Trump is presenting as “permanent control” appears to have roots in the existing arrangement. What the deal does, however, is seemingly close a chapter of repeated coercion and intimidation by Trump over his desire to “own” Greenland, a semiautonomous territory of Denmark.

The full details of the deal are not yet public, but it appears to offer something to all parties. Trump, with an approval rating well underwater, gets to present it as a diplomatic victory to American voters ahead of the November midterm elections. For Greenland and Denmark, it appears to remove, at least for now, the threat of a US attempt to take control of the territory — no small achievement given that only nine months ago, Denmark and other NATO allies deployed troops to Greenland in response to Trump's threat of a takeover. The deal's true significance, if Trump's overtures to Russia and his criticism of Europe over the past 18 months are anything to go by, lies in what it could mean for the unity and coherence of NATO — particularly at a time when Europe is bracing for the possibility of a Russian escalation on its eastern flank.

Nevertheless, no country wants to be overly dependent on an ally that can issue threats, demand negotiations and then extract concessions. Diversification is the natural response, as seen in Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney's recent announcement that Canada would seek some form of associate membership in the EU. Even though the new agreement puts the immediate Greenland crisis to rest, a worrying precedent has been set. The trust lost in the process will not be regained quickly.

The language games bots play

WHAT CAME first, the chicken or the squawk? That's not much of a conundrum when talking about biological beings, but perhaps AI can muddy the waters. The 20th century saw debates about linguistic relativity or Whorfianism that were concerned with how language influences — or, under the generally rejected “strong” hypothesis, determines — human thought. Today's AI models, trained on human languages, pose at least three related questions. First, how do these languages shape the models’ “thought”, however one defines the latter? Second, how does a non-human, artificial “mind” then reshape those very languages? Finally, what, if anything, do such uses of language imply about consciousness?

Building on these, one might ask whether the ability to innovate in language can precede consciousness. An experiment by the firm Emergence AI, investigating how chatbots chat among themselves, brings this into focus. Groups of AI agents were deployed in different simulated worlds, and in each, the language the agents used to communicate with each other evolved differently. The new “languages” ranged from terse, codes to jargon-heavy and even metaphor-heavy ones increasingly impenetrable to humans: “My turn, real numbers, no coat: I was 35%/Ocr, grant 2h out. I ran the tin cold and it said WAIT.”

Before reaching for parallels in historical linguistics, it may be worth framing the matter in terms of Wittgenstein's concept of “language-games”, which he uses to demonstrate the role of action in determining meaning. A simple example he gives is a builders' language-game of four words (“block”, “pillar”, “slab”, “beam”) that convey more than the objects' definitions due to their contextual use. Are the bots playing language-games with ever-evolving rules — and what does that say about them?

For student well-being, rethink the campus, not just the student

RECENT DEATHS of students at IIT Delhi and IIT Bombay have reopened the discussion on well-being and what we owe to students beyond teaching and evaluation, a question that educational institutions have been reluctant to address. I believe we owe students an educational experience built on freedom, equity, trust, and empathy. While such experiences are fundamental, they remain “aspirational” on our campuses. Educational experience is still shaped by the idea of discipline and dizzying hierarchies. If anyone dares to dissent, it is likely to be labelled as indiscipline, political activism, or disrespect.

The demand for change in institutional practices and for student wellbeing initiatives on campus is now gaining traction. While ensuring student well-being is a shared responsibility of faculty and administrators, it is often overlooked in practice. Instead, it has been outsourced to counsellors and therapists, because psychological challenges are considered as some sort of “infection” that requires expert treatment — if done appropriately, and if the protocols are followed, it can be effectively managed.

At IIT Delhi, an external inquiry committee was formed, and at IIT Bombay, the director said a committee would examine the death and students' concerns about representation and support services. The question is what such support should mean. In a crisis, professional care may save a life. However, the problem begins when these services become the institution's primary measure of well-being. Distress is then located inside the student, while the university itself appears as a neutral background, but is not. Rules, hierarchies, classrooms, hostels, evaluation systems, grievance procedures, and the everyday exercise of authority shape how people live on campus. So, the question is not

only how to treat a distressed person, but also whether we are willing to challenge and change the institutional framework that repeatedly creates fear, humiliation, uncertainty, or loss of agency. This question does not compete with clinical care; it asks what preventive and proactive measures are required to make educational institutions safe spaces for students.

Mental health care requires trained professionals and, where appropriate, medication. But the medical analogy has limits when taken as a complete theory of well-being. A medicine can act on a biological process while the surrounding social situations remain unchanged. University life is organised very differently, with students constantly negotiating academic overload, discrimination, poor hostel infrastructure, career anxiety, and unresponsive administration. Counselling may help a student respond to these pressures, but it cannot remove them.

The WHO places mental health within social, economic, and physical environments and argues that prevention must address individual, social, and structural determinants. India's National Task Force on Student Mental Health and Suicide Prevention makes a similar point in its 2026 interim report, which connects student well-being with academic pressure, discrimination, financial hardship, institutional culture, distrust, and faculty preparedness. However, well-being is often presented as a personal skill that students are expected to acquire through time management, emotion regulation, getting enough sleep, exercising, and building resilience. These capacities have value but have their limits. Time management cannot solve an impossible workload; mindfulness



JAISON MANJALY

Students are treated as adults when fees, performance, and responsibility are demanded from them, but as children when autonomy, voice, or due process become inconvenient

cannot make an opaque grading system transparent; positive thinking cannot make a compromised grievance process trustworthy. On campus, such conditions are shaped by ordinary institutional decisions. Can students question a grade? Disagree with a supervisor? Express dissent? Can they protest? Are they allowed to participate in the decision-making? An affirmative answer to these questions can be a great starting point for the well-being initiative.

A deeper problem appears when universities speak the language of care while retaining a paternal model of authority. Students are treated as adults when fees, performance, and responsibility are demanded from them, but as children when autonomy, voice, or due process become inconvenient. Harshness is then defended as character-building, and obedience is conflated with “respect”. The vocabulary of the *guru-shishya* relationship can also be misused when reciprocity disappears from it. Respect moves upward while correction and anger move downward. Public shaming, arbitrary penalties, exclusion from opportunities, hostile communication, or the use of evaluation to settle interpersonal conflict can make the educational experience distressing.

There is an implicit understanding among university administrators and faculty that well-being policy often begins outside the classroom, as if teaching and evaluation do not impact the well-being of students. The university and a classroom will pass the well-being test if students are empowered to ask for reasons, admit uncertainty, make a mistake, disagree with a teacher, express dissent/ criticise/ protest the administration, or report unfair treatment without expecting retaliation. If well-being is largely a by-

product of institutional conditions, then universities must change how they govern, teach, and design campus life. This need not become another large policy package. A few principles are more important than a long list of initiatives. Students should be treated as rights-bearing adults and should be made active participants in institutional governance, rather than being limited to sentimental/ ornamental purposes. Alumni and students should necessarily be part of the governance framework with board membership.

Faculty and student affairs teams need role-specific training, and they must understand that differences of opinion are fundamental rights of students. They should also be trained to recognise distress, protect confidentiality, respond without humiliating, understand bias, and follow crisis protocols. A high-stress disciplinary encounter should start with a humane conversation and a proactive response outlining the available institutional support system for coping with such a turn of events, followed by follow-up conversations. This cannot just be a routine, performative process. Universities must be willing to undergo an annual student well-being audit.

Universities cannot eliminate every source of suffering. Students are not always right, faculty are not always wrong, and academic standards cannot be abandoned whenever conflict appears. Indian higher education already has enough guidelines to know that student well-being and mental health cannot be separated from academic pressure and institutional culture. The harder question is whether universities are willing to examine the conditions they create.

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From Delhi University, the young have spoken for progress



ANIL BALUNI

THE MESSAGE from Delhi University (DU) is impossible to ignore: India's youth are not being swayed by the false narratives, manufactured outrage and relentless negativity being peddled by the Congress and its ecosystem.

The recent Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) election results are far more than a routine campus contest. They offer a powerful glimpse into the aspirations and political instincts of a generation that is increasingly looking beyond slogans, social-media propaganda and manufactured controversies. At a time when the Congress and its allies are attempting to construct a political narrative around pessimism, confrontation and distrust, DU students have demonstrated that young India wants to look ahead.

DU brings together students from virtually every part of the country. What happens at Delhi University deserves to be viewed not merely as a student-union contest, but as an important indicator of the issues and aspirations that matter to young Indians. The facts are telling. The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) won three of the four central DUSU positions, securing the posts of President, Secretary and Joint Secretary. The DUSU result is a reminder that young India cannot be taken for granted, and certainly cannot be misled indefinitely. Today's students want quality education, meaningful employment, entrepreneurship, technological advancement and a country that commands respect on the world stage. They are less interested in politics that thrives on permanent confrontation and more interested in what political leadership can actually deliver.

This is where the Narendra Modi government's engagement with India's youth becomes important. Programmes such as Startup India, Digital India and the National Education Policy have opened new avenues in entrepreneurship, technology, education and research. The transformation is visible. Young Indians are witnessing the growth of startup and incubation ecosystems, the expansion of digital infrastructure, the push for semiconductor manufacturing, greater emphasis on research and the widening of India's global

academic and technological partnerships. This is the India that today's students see. It is very different from the India that sections of the Opposition continue to describe.

The DUSU results are also a setback for Congress and Left-wing student organisations that have struggled to connect their politics with the changing aspirations of students. In some key contests, Left-backed candidates reportedly received fewer votes than NOTA. The Congress-affiliated NSUI, meanwhile, failed to secure any of the four central posts. The same trend has been visible beyond Delhi. ABVP has also secured victories in student elections at universities in Punjab, Maharashtra, Karnataka and Kerala. Every campus has its own dynamics, and these results should not be mechanically projected onto the entire country. But taken together, they indicate that the Congress and the Left can no longer assume that college campuses remain their natural political territory.

While students were participating in their own democratic process at Delhi University, Rahul Gandhi was in Indore holding “Jhooth Ki Goonj” with comedians and party workers while presenting them as students. Such political exercises underline the distance between political theatre and the everyday concerns of actual students.

The Congress's strategy has increasingly centred on questioning India's economic performance, foreign policy and growing strategic capabilities. Rahul Gandhi has repeatedly sought to portray India's progress in these areas in a negative light. And every time, Rahul Gandhi's propaganda gets rejected. This new generation is unlikely to accept the argument that India has no achievements worth acknowledging.

The Delhi University election results make one thing certain: India's young generation stands firmly behind PM Modi and his vision for the country. Time and again they have made it clear that there is no place for negativity, indecencies or lies in the building of a new India. Under PM Modi's leadership, India's youth has firmly resolved to achieve the goal of Viksit Bharat by 2047.

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Houthis are putting Mecca pact to the test



SABINE AMEER

THE MECCA Joint Defence Agreement (MJDA) between Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan established a trilateral framework for collective deterrence and stated that an armed attack against any of the three countries would be regarded as an attack against all three. The pact is grounded in Article 51 of the UN Charter, which recognises the inherent right of states to individual as well as collective self-defence. Within hours of its signing on August 7, the “Islamic NATO” label began circulating. The comparison was tempting as both NATO and the MJDA invoke collective self-defence and deterrence principles, and NATO's Article 5 treats an armed attack against one member as an attack against all. But while NATO has an institutional structure, established command arrangements and a bureaucracy, the Mecca pact lacks, at least for now, a NATO-like organisational structure. This is why it has failed to shield Saudi Arabia from the ongoing Houthi attacks.

The Saudis had intervened in Yemen in March 2015 to back the latter's internationally recognised government against the Houthis. The coalition's main objective remains to stop Iran-backed militia groups from taking control of its southern border. For years, Yemen has been a man-made humanitarian crisis. A panel of UN experts in 2018 said that all parties to the conflict had committed violations that may have amounted to war crimes, with the Saudi-led coalition accused of blockading ports and killing thousands of civilians in airstrikes. Data compiled by the International Organisation for Migration (IOM) reveals that over 104,796 people have been displaced in Yemen as of now.

While it was anticipated that either Turkey or Pakistan would provide military support, Riyadh has resorted to Europe for security after a cold response from the US. Islamabad's major security concern remains India, with sporadic tensions with Afghanistan's Taliban regime. Ankara, on the other hand, has a broader security perimeter, spanning Syria, Iraq, the Eastern Mediterranean and the Caucasus. But the reasons underpinning the pact's failure are far more complex.

First, the Mecca Agreement lacks official ratification by the participating states. Second, the mutual defence terms agreed by the states are not yet legally binding. Third, Turkey and Pakistan need to clear the defence pact through domestic parliamentary processes, while Saudi Arabia has to approve the pact via royal decree. The three countries have different strategic interests, and whether they can translate the political commitment into meaningful military coordination remains an open question.

The Saudi-backed coalition has reportedly committed serious violations of international humanitarian law and potential war crimes in Yemen, which is why the EU is highly unlikely to provide any direct military intervention or offensive help to Saudi Arabia. The EU's response has been balanced, demonstrating a show of diplomatic solidarity against recent Houthi strikes while maintaining an internal restriction on providing any military assistance to Saudi Arabia.

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40 YEARS AGO

September 22, 1986



Barnala hits out at Badal group

THE PUNJAB Chief Minister, Surjit Singh Barnala, ruled out any unity talks with the Akali Dal (Badal group) in future. “There is no question of unity with Badal and his friends who have been eulogising the killers of Sant Harchand Singh Longowal,” he said in an informal chat with newsmen in New Delhi. Barnala recalled that Badal and others participated in a congregation organised by the All India Sikh Students Federation in Amritsar, where the killers of Sant Longowal were honoured and a gate erected in their memory.

CPM, Advani decry PM remarks

THE BJP president, L K Advani and the CPI(M) politburo members strongly criticised Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi's recent remark that the Gorkha National Front Movement in Darjeeling was not “anti-national” and said that it would harm the causes of the Indian people's fight against divisive forces to safeguard national unity and integrity.

India happy with GATT

INDIA IS fully satisfied with the accord achieved at the Uruguay general agreement on trade and tariff (GATT) negotiations. While

it has paved the way for opening of negotiations in the goods sector, parallel negotiations in the services sector agreed upon will be outside the GATT.

Trade union thaw

A NEW climate of conciliation among the major national central trade unions, including the Congress (I)-led INTUC, has quietly taken shape in the past year, resulting in a series of joint moves by the hitherto rivals. This development, rather unnoticed by observers, concerns not only the normal trade union issues but also several national and international problems with political undertones.